

Password Incorrect?

WHEN I FIRST registered for free e-mail in 1997, Net security wasn't a concern. The sign up procedure was a breeze, and the mail service provider wasn't skeptical about my identity, location or even intentions.

Anyone who registered at a free Web mail provider in the last few years knows that this isn't the case today. You're automatically suspected of being a spammer, you have to see the message "This ID has already been taken, please choose another one", and have to squint to recognise letters in a curly font, then type them in correctly to pass the anti-bot test. Finally, just when you think you're done, you have to assign an eight-character password that consists of both upper and lower case letters and at least one number! If all this was done just once, for a single Net ID, it's acceptable, but...

Every site that offers a service, and some that don't, all ask us to register before being able to use them. Common(web)sense says that you should never repeat a user ID-password combination everywhere, so you're left with no choice but to create many different Web identities for your Net pursuits.

In my case it's three Net banking accounts, the Digit forum, two international newswire subscriptions, frequent flyer membership, four Web mail accounts, office mail—the last count stood at 12!

Now which ID goes with which password? If it's not hard enough already, all my Net banking accounts, and some other subscription accounts, require me to change the password at least twice a year—and they refuse to accept previously used passwords! Thus begins the painful process of finding another password that will remain glued to my memory chip for at least 6 months, and permit me to access *my own* bank account details.

Increasing Net threats and web-based crimes have jeopardized the convenience afforded by e-commerce. Can there be a simple solution to this password paranoia?

Thankfully my credit card company (HSBC) has now come up with a smart solution to the security threat. Their gift is a small little digital device on a key chain that throws up a unique 8 digit number every time I press its button. Now I can keep the same user ID and password, and use this seemingly random eight-digit number to act as my security. It's



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unlikely that someone will guess my username and password *and* also be able to physically steal this device from me.

However, a better solution to the perennial password mess is a one time Web identity assigned by either ICANN or the government itself. We have voter identity cards; what stops us from being assigned a permanent Web identity that acts as our passport to secure and hassle-free Web interactions and transactions?

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